



Relabelled, Not Resorted

A contamination audit of recoloured compost-bin lids across ten shared kitchenettes

Mirela Hanke · Bram Ntuli — School of Continuous Improvement

Background

Facilities recoloured the compost-bin lids across ten shared kitchenettes in March, citing confusion with the general-waste stream. Little is known about whether a lid's colour changes what a hand actually drops into the bin, or only what Facilities can point to having changed.

Aims

- Compare compost-stream contamination rates before and after the lid recolour
- Establish whether contamination composition, not just its rate, shifted with the new colour
- Test whether any change tracked the recolour date or each kitchenette's existing signage load

Methods

- 10 shared kitchenettes; hand-sorted bin audits, 6 weeks pre- and 6 weeks post-recolour (Mar–May 2026)
- Item-level contamination coding against the University's compost-eligibility list
- Recolour date and existing signage count held as covariates

Results

Contamination held in the high teens to low twenties across both windows in every kitchenette (17–22% pre, 16–23% post); no kitchenette moved outside its own pre-recolour range.



Contamination held at a median 19.5% pre-recolour and 20.0% post (n = 10 kitchenettes, 12 weeks, Mar–May 2026); every kitchenette's post-recolour reading fell inside its own pre-recolour range.

Discussion & conclusions

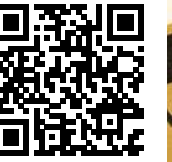
The lids changed; the bins didn't. A null result this clean rarely reaches a decision brief unaltered — this one reached Facilities' June works schedule anyway, filed as evidence the scheme “was landing.” Next: audit the brief, not the bin.

References

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No occupant identifiers retained; bin contents logged by item category only. Ethics exemption 2026/044.

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“The bins came back the same colour of wrong, whatever the lid said.”

10 kitchenettes · 12 weeks · Mar–May 2026